A A S T U

Creativity and Innovation

Chapter 1

Key Theories of Creativity and Innovation

Day 1 (Wednesday) | Morning Session (2 hours) and Afternoon Session (2 hours)

Chapter overview

Why do some people and organizations keep producing fresh ideas while others repeat the same routines year after year? Researchers have studied this question for more than a century, and they have offered several explanations. This chapter introduces seven of them. Each theory looks at creativity and innovation from a different angle. Some look at the world around us, some look at the thinking process, and some look at the person and the people who surround that person.

You do not need a background in psychology or management to follow this chapter. The theories are explained in plain language and connected to situations you meet at work every day, such as handling requests, writing letters, serving clients, keeping records, or caring for patients. Our aim is practical. By the end of the day you should be able to say not only what each theory claims, but also what you can do differently on Monday morning because of it.

Learning outcomes

By the end of Day 1, you will be able to:

- Define creativity and innovation and explain how they differ and depend on each other.
- Describe the main ideas of seven theories: Shrinking Earth, Systems, Honing, Everyday Imaginative Thought, Evolution, Investment, and Social Personality.
- Give a workplace example for each theory from your own department or experience.
- Identify the personal habits and the organizational conditions that help or block new ideas.
- Compare the theories and explain how they complement each other.
- Prepare a short personal action plan to apply at least three ideas from this chapter.

Schedule for the day

Time block	Topic	Minutes
Morning	Opening and introduction to creativity and innovation	10
Morning	1.1.1 Shrinking Earth Theory	20
Morning	1.1.2 Systems Theory	25
Morning	Break	10
Morning	1.1.3 Honing Theory	25
Morning	1.1.4 Everyday Imaginative Thought Theory	25
Morning	Morning recap	5
Afternoon	Welcome back and quick review quiz	10
Afternoon	1.1.5 Evolution Theory	25
Afternoon	1.1.6 Investment Theory	30
Afternoon	Break	10
Afternoon	1.1.7 Social Personality Theory	30
Afternoon	Bringing the theories together and personal action plan	15

How to use this module

- Read the short explanation of each theory, then follow your trainer through the activity.
- Use the blue **Key ideas** boxes to review quickly, the yellow **Activity** boxes during group work, and the green **Check your understanding** boxes to test yourself.
- Write in the module. Your own examples will help you remember far more than the examples printed here.

1.1 Key Theories of Creativity and Innovation

What are creativity and innovation?

Creativity is the ability to produce ideas, solutions, or products that are both **new** and **useful**. A new idea that nobody can use is only a curiosity, and a useful idea that is copied exactly from somewhere else is only good imitation. Creativity needs both qualities together.

Innovation is the process of turning a creative idea into something that is actually put to work and brings value. An innovation can be a new service, a better procedure, a new tool, or a new way of organizing people. It must be tested, accepted, and used.

	Creativity	Innovation
Main question	What new ideas can we imagine?	How do we make the idea work in real life?
Focus	Generating and shaping ideas	Testing, adopting, and spreading ideas
Typical result	A concept, a draft, a plan	A changed service, product, or practice
Typical risk	Ideas that stay on paper	Resistance, cost, and poor planning

In short, creativity supplies the seed and innovation grows it into a plant that bears fruit. An organization needs both. Chapter 2 will follow this journey step by step. In this chapter we ask a more basic question: **how do scholars explain where creativity comes from and why it appears in some situations and not in others?**

Why study theories?

A theory is an organized explanation. It helps us notice things we would otherwise miss. If you believe creativity is a rare gift, you will not bother to encourage it in your team. If you believe it grows from the right conditions and habits, you will act very differently. The theories in this chapter give you a set of lenses. No single lens shows everything, but together they give a rich picture.

The seven theories can be read as seven answers to seven questions:

Theory	The central question it answers
1.1.1 Shrinking Earth	How does a connected world push people and organizations to create?
1.1.2 Systems	How do the person, the field of experts, and the knowledge domain work together?
1.1.3 Honing	How do ideas and the thinker change through repeated refinement?
1.1.4 Everyday Imaginative Thought	Is creativity only for geniuses or part of everyday life?
1.1.5 Evolution	How do many ideas compete and the best survive?
1.1.6 Investment	Why do creative people choose unpopular ideas and what resources do they need?
1.1.7 Social Personality	How do personality traits and the social setting shape creativity?

> **A note for the trainer and trainees**
>
> Some of these theories are presented by their authors under different names, and a few are better understood as broad perspectives than as single formal models. In this module the names follow the course outline, and the content draws on the research literature that is closest to each idea. The reading list at the end of the chapter shows where to go deeper.

MORNING SESSION

Day 1 (Wednesday) | 2 hours | Theories 1.1.1 to 1.1.4

1.1.1 Shrinking Earth Theory

Think about how you receive news today compared with how your grandparents did. A decision made in a capital city on the other side of the world can reach your phone within

seconds. Roads, airlines, mobile networks, and the internet have made distance matter much less than before. People often say that the world has become a small village. This is the starting point of the **Shrinking Earth Theory**.

The theory says that as the world shrinks, **ideas, people, goods, and information travel faster and meet more often**. This meeting of different ideas is a powerful source of creativity and a strong push toward innovation. Creativity here is not only a quality of individuals. It is a response to the environment in which people live and work.

How a shrinking world encourages creativity

- **Exposure to diversity.** When we meet people with different cultures, skills, and habits, our usual way of doing things is challenged. We see that there are other ways.
- **Recombination.** Many new ideas are combinations of old ideas from different places. Mobile money, for example, joined the old idea of a bank account with the mobile phone, and services such as telebirr changed how many Ethiopians pay and send money.
- **Competition and rising expectations.** When clients know what is possible elsewhere, they expect the same quality at home. Organizations must improve or lose trust.
- **Faster spread.** A good practice found in one office can be known by thousands within days, which shortens the time between a new idea and its adoption.
- **Shared problems.** Health, food, climate, and education challenges cross borders, so solutions must be created and shared across borders too.

Limits and cautions

A shrinking world also brings risks. People may copy a practice without asking whether it fits their own context, which is imitation and not innovation. Too much information can cause confusion. Not everyone has equal access to the internet or to training, and this digital gap can leave some people behind. A creative person is therefore not a collector of foreign ideas but an **adapter**, who asks what to keep, what to change, and what to add so that the idea works here.

Key ideas

- The world is more connected, so ideas move quickly and widely.
- Meeting different ideas triggers new combinations and new solutions.
- Creativity means adapting borrowed ideas to local needs and not copying them blindly.
- Access and context matter. The same idea may work well in one place and fail in another.

Activity 1: Idea Import (10 minutes)

Think of one good practice you have seen in another office, university, organization, or country, or learned online or from a colleague. Write your answers below, then share with the person next to you.

- What is the practice and where did you see it?
- What problem in your own work could it help solve?
- What must be changed so that it fits our situation and culture?

Check your understanding

1. Explain in your own words why a smaller world can lead to more creativity.
2. Why is copying an idea from another country not the same as being creative?

1.1.2 Systems Theory

Imagine a young nurse who designs a better patient record sheet. Is she creative? The Systems Theory, developed mainly by the psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, gives an interesting answer: **it depends on more than her**. In this view creativity is not found only inside a person's head. It happens in the **interaction of three parts of a system**.

Part of the system	Meaning	Example in a university or health office
Domain	The body of knowledge, rules, and symbols in a field of work	Records standards, clinical guidelines, university regulations, accounting rules
Field	The people who decide what is good and what is accepted, such as experts, supervisors, committees, and gatekeepers	The clinic head, a quality office, a review committee, senior colleagues
Individual	The person who learns the domain and brings a new variation	The nurse, the secretary, the auditor, or you

According to this theory, an act is creative when an individual makes a change in a domain **and the field accepts that change** so that it becomes part of the domain. An idea that is never noticed or accepted may still be valuable, but it has not yet become a creative contribution in the full sense. This is a humbling and practical lesson. A good idea needs good communication and good relationships as well as good thinking.

Systems thinking in organizations

The word “systems” also reminds us that an organization is a connected whole made of inputs, activities, outputs, and feedback. When you change one part, other parts react. A new form in the registrar’s office changes the work of the finance office. A faster approval process may create more pressure on the archive. Creative people think about these ripple effects before they act and talk to the people who will be affected.

> **Key ideas**
>
> - Creativity emerges from the interaction of the domain, the field, and the individual.
> - To contribute, learn the domain well, understand how the field judges ideas, and present your idea in a language the field respects.
> - Every change in an organization has side effects elsewhere in the system, so think about who will be affected.

Activity 2: Map the System (15 minutes)

In groups of four, choose one routine process in your workplace, such as processing a leave request, receiving a visitor, or registering a document. On flip chart paper:

- Draw the main steps from the first input to the final output.
- Mark who must approve or accept at each step. These are your field.
- Circle one step you would improve and show which other steps would be affected.

Check your understanding

1. Name the three parts of the system in Csikszentmihalyi's theory and give one example of each from your workplace.
2. Why might a good idea fail to be recognized as creative?

1.1.3 Honing Theory

Many people imagine creativity as a flash of lightning. One moment there is nothing, and the next moment a brilliant idea appears. Careful studies of how writers, scientists, and designers actually work show a different picture. Ideas rarely arrive complete. They are shaped slowly through many attempts. The **Honing Theory**, developed by the cognitive scientist Liane Gabora, builds on this observation.

To hone means to sharpen gradually, like a blacksmith honing a blade. In this theory the creative process is a gradual honing of a **mental model** or understanding of the problem. Each draft, sketch, or trial expresses the idea in an outer form, and that outer form teaches the creator something new. The creator then adjusts both the idea and their own way of seeing the problem. The idea changes the thinker, and the thinker changes the idea.

An example: improving a visitor register

Round	What the worker does	What is learned
Draft 1	Makes a simple table with name, date, and time	People forget to write the purpose of the visit

Round	What the worker does	What is learned
Draft 2	Adds a column for purpose and the office to be visited	Visitors are not sure which office is responsible
Draft 3	Adds a short guide at the gate and a sign with office names	Guards need a quick way to call the right office
Draft 4	Adds a phone list and simple instructions for the guards	The process becomes smooth and the worker understands visitors far better than at the start

Notice that no single draft was brilliant. The quality came from the cycle of trying, observing, and adjusting. Notice also that the worker ended the process with a deeper understanding of visitors than at the beginning. Honing Theory suggests that this change in the creator's outlook is an essential part of creativity.

Habits of a good honer

- Start with a rough first version and do not wait for perfection.
- Ask for feedback early from the people who will use the result.
- Keep earlier versions. They show how your thinking has grown.
- After each version ask, "What did this attempt teach me?"
- Give the process enough time. Rushed work leaves no space for honing.

> **Key ideas**
>
> - Creativity is often gradual refinement and not a sudden flash.
> - Each version of an idea reveals something and changes the creator's understanding.
> - Feedback, patience, and repeated adjustment are central to creative work.

Activity 3: Three Drafts (15 minutes)

Choose a small work item, such as a form, a notice, or a meeting agenda template. You will improve it in three rounds of three minutes each. After every round, swap with your neighbor, who writes one comment. At the end, discuss: how did your thinking change between the first and the third version?

Check your understanding

1. What does it mean to "hone" an idea?
2. How does Honing Theory challenge the belief that creativity is a flash of genius?

1.1.4 Everyday Imaginative Thought Theory

Is creativity only for famous inventors, great artists, and scientists who win prizes? The **Everyday Imaginative Thought Theory** answers no. It holds that creativity grows out of **ordinary human imagination**, the same mental ability we use when we daydream, plan a journey, think "what if", tell a story, cook with the ingredients we have, or repair a broken tool with whatever is nearby.

Psychologists have a helpful way to describe different levels of creativity. In the Four C model proposed by James Kaufman and Ronald Beghetto, creativity ranges from small personal discoveries to world-changing achievements.

Level	Meaning	Example
Mini-c	A new personal insight during learning	A trainee suddenly understands how two procedures connect
Little-c	Everyday creativity in work and home life	A secretary invents a colour code that makes filing faster
Pro-c	Professional-level creativity built on expertise	An engineer designs a cheaper water filter for a rural school
Big-C	Rare, historic achievements that change a field	Major scientific discoveries and great works of art

Everyone starts with mini-c and little-c. These levels are the soil from which higher levels can grow. In most workplaces, the bulk of valuable innovation comes from many small improvements made by ordinary people who think carefully about their daily tasks. If you believe that you are not creative, this theory invites you to look again at the small clever things you already do.

Tools of everyday imagination

- **"What if" questions.** What if we did this step first and not last? What if the client filled in the form?
- **Reversal.** Turn an assumption upside down. Instead of asking how to reduce complaints, ask how we could make clients happier.
- **Making do with constraints.** Limited money, time, or materials often force us to find clever solutions.
- **Role switching.** Imagine you are the client, the new employee, or the manager. How does the process look from there?

What blocks everyday creativity?

The strongest blocks are inside us. They include the belief "I am not a creative person", fear of being laughed at, and the comfort of routine. Remove these and imagination becomes available to everyone.

> **Key ideas**
>
> - Creativity is part of ordinary thinking and is not limited to geniuses.
> - The Four C model shows a ladder from mini-c to Big-C and everyone can climb it.
> - Small daily improvements add up to real innovation in organizations.

> **Activity 4: Five What-Ifs (10 minutes)**
>
> Pick one routine task you do every week. Write five "what if" questions about it. Choose your most interesting question and share it with the group. Example: What if clients could track the status of their request without visiting our office?

Check your understanding

1. Give one example of mini-c and one example of little-c from your own life.
2. Why do small everyday improvements matter for an organization?

Morning recap (5 minutes)

In one sentence each: (1) The world is connected, so ideas travel and combine. (2) Creativity needs the domain, the field, and the individual. (3) Ideas are honed through repeated drafts. (4) Everyone has everyday imagination. Before lunch, write down one idea from this morning that you want to try this week.

AFTERNOON SESSION

Day 1 (Wednesday) | 2 hours | Theories 1.1.5 to 1.1.7 and Synthesis

Welcome back: quick review (10 minutes)

Without looking at your notes, write one sentence on each of the four theories from the morning. Then compare with a partner and correct each other. Your trainer will ask a few volunteers to share.

1.1.5 Evolution Theory

In nature, living things vary. Some variations help an animal survive in its environment and are passed on, while others disappear. Over a long time, this process of variation and selection produces new species. The psychologist Donald Campbell proposed in 1960 that creative thinking follows a similar pattern, and Dean Keith Simonton later developed this idea into a Darwinian view of creativity. The **Evolution Theory** says that creativity works through **blind variation and selective retention**.

Stage	Key question	What it looks like at work
Variation	How many different ideas can we produce?	Brainstorming many options, trying several designs, collecting suggestions from all staff
Selection	Which ideas fit our needs best?	Testing options against clear criteria, running small pilots, getting user feedback
Retention	How do we keep and spread what works?	Writing the new procedure, training staff, and making it standard practice

The word “blind” does not mean that creators think carelessly. It means that nobody can know in advance which idea will succeed. Even experts are often surprised. Because of this, **producing many ideas increases the chance of finding a good one**. Simonton noted that highly creative people typically produce a great deal of work, and so they have many successes but also many failures. Quantity is not the enemy of quality. It is one of its roads.

Critics point out that creators are often guided by knowledge and judgment and are not completely blind. This is true, and the theory is best used as a reminder that **creative work needs both generation and selection** and that we must not judge ideas too early. If we criticize every idea the moment it appears, we kill variation before it can grow.

Application in organizations

Many successful innovation systems follow this pattern. Staff submit suggestions, a team selects the most promising ones, a small pilot tests them, and the successful pilot becomes policy. Failed pilots are not punished. They are treated as the natural cost of learning.

Key ideas

- Creativity involves producing many varied ideas, selecting the fittest, and retaining what works.
- No one can predict which idea will succeed, so generate many and test them.
- Separate idea generation from idea evaluation. Do not criticize too early.

Activity 5: Idea Tournament (15 minutes)

In groups, take 5 minutes to list as many ideas as possible for improving service to students or visitors. Then select the best three using three criteria: useful, feasible, and affordable. Finally, describe in two sentences how you would test the winning idea on a small scale before adopting it.

Check your understanding

1. What do the words “variation”, “selection”, and “retention” mean in creative work?
2. Why is it unwise to criticize ideas too early in a brainstorming session?

1.1.6 Investment Theory

A wise investor buys shares when their price is low and sells them when the price is high. Robert Sternberg and Todd Lubart proposed that creative people do something similar with ideas. According to their **Investment Theory**, creative people **“buy low and sell high” in the world of ideas**. They choose ideas that are unknown, unpopular, or even doubted by others,

which means they have low value in the market at that time. They work hard to develop these ideas and to persuade others. When the idea becomes accepted and valued, they "sell high" and move on to the next promising but unpopular idea.

This explains why creative people often meet resistance. A new idea looks strange at first, and the crowd prefers what is familiar. Creativity is partly an act of **defying the crowd** while staying realistic.

Six resources of creative investors

Sternberg and Lubart argue that creativity needs six resources that work together, and a weakness in one can sometimes be balanced by strength in another.

Resource	What it means	In the workplace
Intellectual abilities	Seeing problems in new ways, judging which ideas deserve effort, and persuading others of their value	You can spot a hidden problem, decide if it is worth solving, and explain it clearly
Knowledge	Enough knowledge of the field to move it forward, but not so much that it traps thinking in old patterns	You know the rules well but you can ask whether a rule still serves its purpose
Thinking styles	A preference for thinking in new ways and for setting one's own direction	You enjoy designing better methods and not only following instructions
Personality	Willingness to take sensible risks, persist through obstacles, and tolerate uncertainty	You continue even when a first attempt fails
Motivation	Being driven by interest in the task itself and not only by rewards	You work on improvement because you care about the result
Environment	A setting that supports and rewards new ideas	Leaders listen, give time, and protect those who try new things

"Selling high" also requires skill. A new idea needs evidence, clear communication, and patience. A trainee who proposes a digital attendance system should collect simple data from

a small trial, show the time saved, and explain how the change will help colleagues. Persuasion is part of the investment.

Key ideas

- Creative people pursue ideas that are undervalued and then help others see their value.
- Six resources interact: intellectual abilities, knowledge, thinking styles, personality, motivation, and environment.
- Persuasion and persistence are as important as the idea itself.

Activity 6: Resource Check (15 minutes)

Rate yourself honestly from 1 (very low) to 5 (very high) on each resource. Choose the one you most want to invest in during the next three months and write one concrete step. Share with a partner.

Resource	My rating (1 to 5)	One step to strengthen it
Intellectual abilities		
Knowledge		
Thinking styles		
Personality		
Motivation		
Environment		

Check your understanding

1. Explain what it means to “buy low and sell high” with ideas.
2. Which of the six resources is strongest in you, and which needs the most attention?

1.1.7 Social Personality Theory

The last theory asks a question that every manager and every team member should think about: **are creative people born that way, or does the setting make them creative?** The **Social Personality Theory** replies that both matter. Creativity comes from the meeting of certain personal traits and a supportive social environment.

The personality side

Research reviews, such as those by Gregory Feist, suggest that creative people tend to share some traits. They are curious and open to new experiences, they are independent in their thinking, they tolerate uncertainty, they are self-confident, and they persist when work becomes difficult. These traits are not fixed forever. Many can be developed through practice and through experience of success.

The social side

Teresa Amabile's well-known work shows that creativity depends on three components within a person: skills and knowledge in the domain, skills in creative thinking, and **intrinsic task motivation**. Intrinsic motivation means doing something because it is interesting, enjoyable, or satisfying in itself. Her research found that people are usually more creative when they feel motivated by interest and challenge than when they feel pressured by threats, strict surveillance, or heavy competition. The social environment can raise or lower this motivation.

What supports creativity	What blocks creativity
Freedom to decide how to do the work	Constant monitoring and rigid control
Interesting and challenging tasks	Harsh criticism and ridicule of new ideas
Enough time and basic resources	Unrealistic deadlines without explanation
Encouragement and recognition from leaders	Fear of punishment for mistakes
Teams with diverse skills and open talk	Unhealthy internal competition and distrust

Culture matters too. In workplaces where respect for seniority is strong, junior staff may hesitate to share ideas even when they are excellent. Wise leaders therefore create safe ways to speak, such as short idea meetings, anonymous suggestion channels, and a habit of thanking people who raise problems.

Key ideas

- Creativity comes from the interaction of personal traits and the social environment.
- Intrinsic motivation is a powerful driver of creativity.
- Leaders can build or destroy creativity through the climate they create.

Activity 7: Climate Check (15 minutes)

Working alone first, list three things in your office that help creativity and three that block it. Then in groups, combine your lists and choose one blocker that you personally can influence. Write one action you will take, for example thanking a colleague for a new suggestion or sharing a small idea in the next team meeting.

Check your understanding

1. What is intrinsic motivation and why does it matter for creativity?
2. Give two ways a leader can improve the climate for creativity in an office.

Bringing the seven theories together

The seven theories are not rivals. They describe different parts of the same story. Three of them focus on the **environment**: Shrinking Earth, Systems, and Social Personality. Two focus on the **process** of creating: Honing and Evolution. Two focus on the **person**: Everyday Imaginative Thought and Investment. A creative organization pays attention to all three at once.

Theory	Core idea	What you can do
Shrinking Earth	A connected world spreads and mixes ideas	Learn from others and adapt ideas to your context
Systems	Domain, field, and individual interact	Master your field and build support for your ideas
Honing	Ideas are refined through repeated drafts	Start rough, seek feedback, and improve step by step

Theory	Core idea	What you can do
Everyday Imaginative Thought	Creativity is part of ordinary thinking	Ask “what if” about daily tasks and value small improvements
Evolution	Variation, selection, and retention	Generate many ideas, pilot the best, and standardize what works
Investment	Buy low and sell high with ideas using six resources	Develop your resources and learn to persuade
Social Personality	Traits and climate together shape creativity	Protect motivation and create a safe, supportive climate

Activity 8: My Creativity Commitments (15 minutes)

Complete the sentences below. Be specific and realistic. Your trainer will invite a few volunteers to share their first commitment.

- From the theory of _____, I will start doing _____ by _____ (date).
- From the theory of _____, I will stop or change _____ by _____ (date).
- To help my team, I will _____ at our next meeting.

Chapter summary

- Creativity is producing ideas that are new and useful. Innovation is putting those ideas into practice to create value.
- Shrinking Earth Theory explains how a connected world spreads ideas and pushes us to adapt and create.
- Systems Theory shows that creativity depends on the domain, the field, and the individual working together.
- Honing Theory describes creativity as gradual refinement of ideas and of the creator’s own understanding.

- Everyday Imaginative Thought Theory reminds us that creativity belongs to ordinary people and ordinary tasks.
- Evolution Theory presents creativity as variation, selection, and retention of ideas.
- Investment Theory says creative people buy low and sell high with ideas and use six interacting resources.
- Social Personality Theory links personal traits with a supportive or blocking social environment.

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Creativity	Producing ideas or products that are new and useful
Innovation	Turning a creative idea into a tested and used practice, product, or service
Domain	The body of knowledge and rules in a field of work
Field	The people who judge and accept new contributions in a domain
Honing	Gradually refining an idea and the understanding behind it
Little-c creativity	Everyday creativity that improves ordinary work and life
Variation and selective retention	Producing many ideas, choosing the best, and keeping what works
Intrinsic motivation	Doing a task because it is interesting or satisfying in itself

Review questions for discussion or homework

1. Explain the difference between creativity and innovation with an example from your office.
2. Which of the seven theories do you find most useful for your own work, and why?
3. Choose two theories and show how they complement each other.
4. Describe an idea in your workplace that failed to be accepted. Use Systems Theory or Investment Theory to explain what may have happened.

5. What are three things a leader can do tomorrow to strengthen creative thinking in a team?
6. Describe a time when you honed an idea through several versions. What did you learn?

Further reading

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- Simonton, D. K. (1999). Origins of Genius: Darwinian Perspectives on Creativity. Oxford University Press.
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> **Coming next: Day 2 (Thursday)**
>
> Tomorrow’s chapter moves from the theories to practice. We will follow the steps through which creative ideas are born and become innovations, and you will practice them on real workplace challenges.